bonds but attempting to reassure Pakistan, which looks on India–Afghan relations with suspicion, Modi stated, ‘You know that India is here to contribute, not to compete; to lay the foundations of future, not light the flame of conflict; to rebuild lives, not destroy a nation. You know, as we do, that Indians and Afghans have always stood for each other, never against another.’[9]

South Asia is not the only region where India seeks to expand its influence. India offers other developing countries technical and economic assistance provided through the International Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) programme. Almost 64 per cent of the annual budget outlay of the Ministry of External Affairs is spent as international aid under this programme.[10] Other avenues of Indian assistance to developing countries are educators, teachers, doctors and technical trainers. An immensely successful mode of expanding India’s civilizational sphere of influence has been the export of Bollywood movies, which have access to a global market.

In addition to defining South Asia as its virtual sphere of influence and asserting leadership in the developing world, India has always taken pride in its civilizational inheritance and made it an integral part of its world view. This pride has also created a sense of Indian exceptionalism: the belief that India is unique, it is special, was one of the centres of the ancient world and will, once again, find its rightful place. India’s rise is seen as an inevitability, an eventuality that is waiting to happen and that nothing and no one can prevent. During the national struggle for independence, Indian leaders and thinkers also emphasized the idea of India as a beacon for the world, both because of its ancient past but also because of the expected future.

In this iteration of India’s exceptionalism, other developing countries could learn from India and benefit from the Indian experience. Because India is different, it would not be a leader like the former colonial powers or